

Incident Alert 0002. TLP Green.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	IT, FR, DE, PL. Pro-Russian Ads Campaigns Approved by Meta from May 1 to May 27, 2024 in Italy, Germany, France & Poland	29/05/2024	2

Summary

- Between May 1st and 27th, 2024, Meta (Facebook & Instagram) approved at least 275 Pro-Russian ads.
- The ads are lacking Political disclaimers, bypassing Meta's moderation systems by hidden characters and word obfuscation.
- The ads reached 3 075 063 accounts in Italy, France, Germany and Poland.
- Meta is not adequately prevent the misuse of its advertising systems.
- There was a notable increase in the reach of pro-Russian ads in recent weeks, targeting new countries.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

Between May 1st, 2024, and May 27th, 2024, Meta approved at least 275 pro-Russian propaganda ads without political disclaimers to target France and Germany.

These ads collectively reached 3 075 063 accounts:

- 61 ads reached a total of 1 441 543 Italian accounts;
- 101 ads reached a total of 854 052 French accounts;
- 75 ads reached a total of 429 369 German accounts;
- 38 ads reached a total of 350 099 Polish accounts.

With the EU elections less than two weeks away, our findings indicate that Meta still fails to adequately prevent the misuse of its advertising systems for spreading misleading information and foreign information manipulation and interference related to electoral processes. There has been a notable increase in the reach of pro-Russian propaganda ads in recent weeks. New target countries include Italy and Poland, alongside the previously targeted France and Germany.

Advertisements violating terms of service exploit basic techniques, such as hidden characters and word obfuscation, to bypass Meta's lax moderation systems. Hidden characters, like zero-width non-joiners, are inserted into text, and words are split with dots and spaces, making it difficult for naive automated filters to detect inappropriate content. Addressing this issue could be as simple as removing such unicode characters and detecting obfuscated words.

Narrative

Attempting to create division in Italy, France, Poland and Germany by spreading false information.

Impact

Reach: Social media ads, reaching 3.075.063 accounts. Detailed reach per ad in report.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: - Degrade adversary, Discredit credible source, Distort, Distract, Dismay, Divide.

[Deliver Ads](#) - Using ads to reach their target audience without political labeling.

[Manipulate Platform Algorithm](#) - Ads were edited to make the text harder to machine read, most likely to avoid detection by Meta's automated content moderation.

Recommendations

- Action taken: ads reported to Meta 27/05/2024 – Meta suppressed ads listed in the report on 29/05/2025.
- Report sent to European Commission.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Attached Pro Russian ads		Narrative analysis	Paul Bouchaud - AI Forensics Amaury Lesplingart CheckFirst	Ads	Facebook, Instagram